

GETTY IMAGES

The daunting task for Ajit is to create a political space outside the shadow of uncle Sharad Pawar. The Bahujan outreach shows his intent

The defection, coming days after Prime Minister Narendra Modi had attacked the NCP for "scams worth Rs 70,000 crore", led to much talk about whether it had more to do with the fear of investigating agencies than what he claimed: concern for Maharashtra's development.

Ajit *dada*'s image being woven of a fibre where only a legal trail could have caused real damage, that did not matter as much as what effect his tilting of the power axis would have on the behaviour of Maharashtra's 48 Lok Sabha seats in 2024. With its partnership with the old Sena intact in 2019, the NDA had taken 41 of those seats. The birth of the Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) altered that equation a bit, so ensuring a robust show—if not a full encore—was vital for the BJP. Apparently, disquiet was growing on Shinde's capacity to deliver, or the popularity of what someone unkindly called his Alibaba's entourage of 40 rebels. Word was they may have forfeited the support of the Sena cadre and voter, entities psychologically bound to the old monolith. Conversely, NCP satraps, with their strong base in cooperatives, are said to be able to carry the loyalties of workers and voters when they travel.

But it's not all good: they say Ajit is a shadow of his past self, when he virtually ran the show as deputy to then CM Uddhav Thackeray in the MVA coalition. Now, he has to contend with Shinde, a mass leader, not to speak of the other deputy CM (and home minister), Devendra Fadnavis. The more daunting task for Ajit is to carve out a political space outside the shadow of his uncle, who retains strong pockets of support, especially among the dominant Marathas.

To his credit, unlike Shinde, whose identity seems to have been subsumed by senior ally BJP, Ajit has kept a modicum of independence, at least for now. The other day, he ignored an invite from the BJP to the RSS HQ in Nagpur. "It is our right not to go there," said an Ajit faction man. Unlike a reluctant BJP, he has also batted unequivocally for a caste census. That's part of his evolving attempt to create a larger 'Bahujan' constituency for his NCP, even though Maratha-OBC ties are fraught after an agitation by activist Manoj Jarange-Patil seeking OBC status for Marathas. He needs a touch of that creative politics if his coup is to bear fruit: he has always had an eye on the CM's cabin on the sixth floor of Mantralaya in Mumbai. But for that, he must deliver the NCP vote to the NDA in the general election as well as the assembly poll due in October. Can he? ■

PAWAR SUPPLY

- **As the third wheel in the Shinde-Fadnavis regime, Ajit looks out of his element, a far cry from when he was calling the shots in the Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) regime**
- **Despite his gruff image, Ajit is a man of moderation, a teetotaller and also an early riser**
- **His acolytes says Ajit is a man of his word, never making empty promises, especially in personal dealings**
- **A major flaw is his reckless way with words. The 2013 incident when, in the middle of a dilapidating drought, he asked protesting farmers whether he should pee into an empty dam to provide them water, will never go away**